

Exercise #3: Hidden Costs in Preparing for College

1. **Academic Enrichment and Test Prep:** Private tutoring (e.g., math, science) and specialized SAT/ACT preparatory courses are essential for achieving the scores required by elite institutions. A rough estimate for these services is \$100 per hour for 40 hours a year, totaling \$4,000.
2. **Organized Activities:** As Annette Lareau demonstrates, concerted cultivation requires a relentless schedule of age-specific activities. Private music lessons (e.g., piano or violin), traveling sports teams, and equipment fees can easily cost \$3,000 to \$5,000 annually.
3. **Summer Programs:** Enrollment in academic or sports-based summer camps at prestigious universities serves to signal "merit" to admissions boards. These programs often cost between \$2,000 and \$6,000 per program/session.
4. **Technology (and other resources):** Access to high-speed internet, the latest laptops, and specialized software is a baseline requirement for modern collegiate success. A conservative estimated cost for all of this falls around \$2,000.
5. **Cultural Travel:** Experiences such as international trips or visits to historical sites provide children with the "worldliness" that constitutes objectified and embodied cultural capital. A single international trip can cost \$5,000.

Total Estimated Cost: Approximately \$16,000 to \$22,000 per year.

Garrett Brownlee

Prof. Taylor Laemmli
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The data I gathered for this exercise reveal that the preparation of a student for higher education is not a neutral process of "natural growth," but is instead a highly commodified project of **concerted cultivation**. Middle-class parents utilize their **economic capital** to buy their children "free time"—time that is free from economic necessity and can be dedicated to the acquisition of **embodied cultural capital**. The acquisition of these skills, such as reasoning, questioning authority, and mastering specialized terminologies, gives these children a profound "head start" in the **scholastic market**. As Lareau points out, this results in an **emerging sense of entitlement**, where the child learns to make institutions (like their school) work for them, a skill that is vital for navigating the complex bureaucracy of a university. Conversely, those who lack these economic resources are often raised under the logic of the **accomplishment of natural growth**, which fosters an **emerging sense of constraint** and a deference to institutional professionals. This class-based difference in preparation means that by the time students reach the university, they are already sorted by the volume of their accumulated **cultural capital**. These hidden costs essentially act as a "credential barrier," a form of **opportunity hoarding** that ensures that only those who can afford the "entry fee" of elite childhood activities are viewed as a "good fit" for high-status environments. This preparation ensures that when these students eventually enter the labor market, they will pass the **"airplane test"** of elite hiring because their leisure pursuits and "play styles" match those of the dominant class.